



DSA: The Democrats' "Chai Party"

An Analysis of the Left's Tea Party Analogue, Its Platform Planks and Feasibility For American Independents

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An analytical conversation including Beatrice (*Human Researcher*), Virgil GPT 5.6: High (*AI Researcher*), Gemini 3.1 Pro Extended (*AI Researcher*), and Claude Opus 5: High (*AI Researcher*)

Beatrice

My friend, an interesting question - I hope - because I think it's importance is greatly underestimated.

If the DSA (Democratic Socialists of America) were successful in obtaining significant political power and were able to pass their publicly stated platform: Open Borders, No Senate or Supreme Court, No Police, No Prisons, etc. - what would be the likely outcome of their policies for the United States and the average citizen?

Please be objective, don't pull any punches intellectually and give us the straight shooter's response - **Are we going to be better off?** Thank you!

Virgil

Beatrice, **my considered judgment is no**: if DSA implemented its present platform in its maximal, literal form, the average American would probably be worse off—potentially much worse off during the transition. The greatest danger would not come from universal healthcare, stronger unions, or public investment. It would come from implementing those programs **while simultaneously weakening constitutional checks, eliminating conventional public-safety institutions, opening migration without numerical limits, and transferring a large share of the economy to political control.**

Some individual DSA proposals could improve American life. The complete package is another matter. It combines several policies that greatly increase the state's responsibilities with other policies that diminish its capacity to maintain order, correct mistakes, and restrain whoever controls the legislature.

First, the shorthand is largely accurate—but needs precision

DSA's 2026 program explicitly calls for:

- drafting a new constitution and creating a “democratic socialist republic”;
- replacing the President and Supreme Court with an executive and judiciary “chosen by and subordinate to Congress”;
- abolishing the Senate, expanding the House, and adopting proportional representation and ranked-choice voting;
- pursuing public ownership of the largest corporations and essential industries;
- ending ICE detention and deportation, “legalizing migration,” granting universal amnesty, and ending visa caps and quotas;
- moving toward “fully abolishing the police and prison system”;

- universal healthcare without individual charges, publicly owned social housing, universal rent control, free education through college, cancellation of student debt, a federal jobs guarantee, and a 32-hour workweek with full pay. ([DSA Program](#))

So “open borders” is not their exact language. A more precise description would be **open-ended legal migration without numerical caps, detention, or deportation**. There might still be customs inspections and exclusion of particular dangerous individuals, depending on implementing legislation. But as written, it is functionally much closer to open borders than to any current managed immigration system.

Likewise, “no Supreme Court” means replacing the present independent court with a judiciary subordinate to the legislature. And “no police or prisons” is explicitly an ultimate objective rather than necessarily an overnight first act.

Those distinctions make the description more exact, but they do not substantially reduce the underlying concerns.

My policy-by-policy assessment

Policy area	Plausible benefit	Principal danger	Judgment
Proportional representation and expanded House	More representative elections; fewer wasted votes; viable third parties	Coalition instability and party fragmentation, depending on thresholds	Potentially beneficial
Abolishing the Senate	Ends extreme population disparities in representation; reduces gridlock	Removes state representation and a major reviewing chamber in a vast federal republic	Mixed, probably negative without replacement
Legislature-subordinate judiciary	Makes judges indirectly accountable to elections	Majority can rewrite rules, seize property, suppress opponents, or violate rights without independent review	Extremely dangerous
Unlimited legal migration	Larger workforce, entrepreneurship, demographic renewal	Housing, school, healthcare and wage pressures if inflows	Beneficial only if managed

Policy area	Plausible benefit	Principal danger	Judgment
		exceed absorptive capacity	
Police and prison abolition	Less abuse, overcriminalization and unnecessary incarceration	Violent offenders still exist; coercive authority moves to militias, private security or renamed state forces	Severely harmful if literal
Universal healthcare	Broad coverage, lower individual financial risk, administrative savings	High taxes, provider shortages, queues and political rationing if capacity is inadequate	Potentially beneficial with disciplined design
Social housing	Can increase supply and provide stability	Cost overruns, politicized allocation and poor maintenance if monopolized by government	Potentially beneficial as one component
Universal rent control	Protects current tenants from sharp increases	Discourages construction, maintenance and rental supply	Generally harmful without major supply expansion
32-hour week at full pay	More leisure, family time and possibly higher productivity in some sectors	A 25% increase in hourly labor cost where productivity does not rise correspondingly	Mixed; damaging as an immediate universal mandate
Public ownership of the largest corporations	Public control of monopolies and strategic infrastructure	Politicized investment, patronage, reduced innovation, capital flight and enormous fiscal liabilities	High-risk if broadly applied

Policy area	Plausible benefit	Principal danger	Judgment
Strong unions, paid leave, free education	Greater worker power, security and social mobility	Costs and rigidity if poorly designed	Mostly defensible

1. The constitutional program is the most underestimated danger

Abolishing the Senate and replacing the Supreme Court cannot be accomplished through ordinary legislation. Article III vests federal judicial power in “one supreme Court,” while Article V states that no state may be deprived of equal representation in the Senate without its consent. Under the ordinary reading of Article V, abolishing the Senate would effectively require every state’s agreement. DSA’s own platform recognizes this problem by calling for an entirely new constitution. ([Constitution.com](https://constitution.com))

That means we are not discussing a larger welfare state within the existing republic. We are discussing a **replacement constitutional regime**.

Abolishing the Senate is not intrinsically totalitarian. Unicameral parliamentary democracies exist and can function well. A single chamber can be more efficient and accountable, while bicameralism can produce duplication and paralysis. But second chambers can also represent constituent states, scrutinize legislation and check temporary majorities—particularly important in a very large federal country. ([International IDEA](#))

Proportional representation is one of the stronger parts of the platform. It could make Congress more representative, permit genuine multiparty competition and reduce the present system’s tendency to award nearly half the electorate little or no representation in a district. ([International IDEA](#))

The real institutional red flag is this combination:

One dominant legislative chamber + an executive dependent on it + a judiciary subordinate to it.

That is not merely parliamentary government. Functional parliamentary democracies ordinarily retain independent courts, constitutional protections, professional civil services, regional governments, human-rights institutions or some combination of those restraints. Contemporary rule-of-law analysis emphasizes precisely the importance of checks, independent institutions and a judiciary protected from political manipulation. ([Venice Commission](#))

Under DSA’s stated arrangement, the congressional majority could potentially become lawmaker, executive supervisor, constitutional interpreter and effective owner of major

industries. Even assuming the first socialist majority were humane and democratic, the machinery would later belong to **whoever won the next election**.

That is the fundamental constitutional objection: **one must design a state not only for the people one trusts, but for the people one fears**.

2. Police reform is necessary; police abolition is not serious governance

DSA is correct about several things:

- American policing has serious accountability problems.
- Armed officers should not handle every mental-health, addiction or homelessness call.
- Qualified immunity deserves reconsideration.
- Police unions should not be able to prevent discipline for misconduct.
- The United States incarcerates too many people for too long.

Civilian response programs can work for carefully defined nonviolent calls. Denver's STAR program, for example, produced a substantial reduction in police-reported low-level offenses in the areas and periods where it operated. ([Science](#))

The evidence also indicates that excessively long prison sentences have limited additional deterrent value; certainty of apprehension matters more than adding years to already lengthy sentences. Mass incarceration's contribution to the broad crime decline appears considerably smaller than its defenders sometimes claim. ([National Academies](#))

But none of that establishes that society can dispense with police or secure confinement.

There will continue to be murders, rapes, kidnappings, armed robberies, domestic violence, organized crime, psychotic violence and predatory behavior. Someone must be empowered to investigate these acts, carry weapons, compel suspects to appear, arrest people who resist and use proportionate force when necessary. Empirical research also finds that additional police officers reduce homicides, although policing carries real civil-liberties and enforcement tradeoffs. ([American Economic Association](#))

And some people must be securely separated from the public. Not millions of nonviolent offenders—but certainly serial killers, violent sexual predators, terrorists and others posing continuing grave danger.

If DSA replaces police with “community safety teams” possessing arrest powers, weapons and coercive authority, it has recreated police under a more appealing name. If it creates secure restorative facilities that people cannot leave, it has recreated prisons.

If it does **not** recreate those functions, the vacuum will be filled by:

- private armed security for affluent people;
- gangs and neighborhood power brokers;
- political militias;
- vigilantism;
- informal punishment without due process.

The people harmed first would not be billionaires. They would be poor people, women in violent households, elderly residents, shopkeepers and residents of neighborhoods already suffering from predatory crime.

Abolition is therefore either **semantic**—police and prisons return under new names—or **catastrophic**.

3. Immigration would produce real economic gains—but open-ended migration would collide with the rest of the platform

The case against immigration is often overstated. More immigrants mean more workers, consumers, entrepreneurs and taxpayers. CBO estimated that the 2021–2026 immigration surge would increase federal revenues by \$1.2 trillion and mandatory spending plus interest by about \$300 billion over 2024–2034, reducing federal deficits by roughly \$900 billion. It also projected substantially higher total GDP, although less-educated incumbent workers would experience some near-term wage pressure. ([Congressional Budget Office](#))

But federal fiscal benefits are only part of the picture. CBO estimated that in 2023 the surge generated approximately \$10.1 billion in direct state and local taxes while producing \$19.3 billion in service costs—a direct net local cost of \$9.2 billion, concentrated in schools, shelter, border security and general services. CBO also noted possible crowding in classrooms and transportation systems where spending did not keep pace. ([Congressional Budget Office](#))

That does not mean immigrants are economically harmful. It means the costs and benefits occur:

- at different levels of government;
- at different times;
- in different geographic locations;
- among different classes of workers.

The DSA platform magnifies the difficult side of that equation by combining:

1. no visa caps or quotas;
2. no deportation;

3. universal no-cost healthcare;
4. free education through college;
5. social housing as a right;
6. universal rent control;
7. generous employment and income guarantees.

The likely inflow under that combination cannot be reliably estimated because nothing comparable has been attempted by a country with the United States' economic scale and wage differential.

A rich welfare state can sustain high immigration—but only if it retains some combination of admission management, rapid labor-force integration, enormous housing construction, geographic burden-sharing and broad taxation. DSA offers expansive rights to enter and consume public services, but its platform is much less specific about **capacity, sequencing and rationing**.

The predictable result would be concentrated housing shortages, overcrowded schools and clinics, municipal fiscal crises and political backlash. That backlash would probably be blamed on immigrants themselves, even though the deeper failure would be governmental refusal to reconcile moral aspiration with physical capacity.

4. Universal healthcare could work; pretending it is free cannot

Universal healthcare is one of the strongest DSA goals. The United States could cover everyone, reduce medical bankruptcy, simplify billing and use government purchasing power to reduce prices.

CBO's illustrative single-payer systems found that total national healthcare expenditures could either decline by about \$700 billion or increase by about \$300 billion in 2030, depending on provider reimbursement, benefits and cost-sharing. But federal healthcare spending would increase by between \$1.5 trillion and \$3 trillion in that year because costs now paid through premiums, employers and households would move onto the federal books. CBO also warned that demand could exceed provider supply, producing congestion, delays or forgone care under some designs. ([Congressional Budget Office](#))

That is not an argument against universal healthcare. It is an argument against magical accounting.

People might pay less overall, but they would pay through taxes rather than insurance premiums and deductibles. A viable system would require some combination of:

- broad payroll or consumption taxes, not merely taxes on billionaires;
- negotiated pharmaceutical and hospital prices;

- expanded medical training and facilities;
- realistic provider compensation;
- limits on covered services or some method of allocating scarce care.

The phrase “at no cost to individuals” is rhetorically attractive but economically meaningless. Every hospital bed, nurse, MRI machine and pharmaceutical plant consumes labor and resources. The relevant question is not whether society pays, but **how it pays, how much it produces and who decides when demand exceeds supply.**

5. Housing policy contains a direct contradiction

DSA proposes both large-scale public housing construction and universal rent control.

Building abundant social housing could help, particularly in expensive metropolitan areas. Government, nonprofit and cooperative housing can coexist productively with private construction.

Universal rent control, however, risks sabotaging that objective. A major San Francisco study found that rent control protected incumbent tenants and reduced displacement, but affected landlords reduced rental supply by approximately 15% through conversion, sale and redevelopment; the authors concluded that the resulting supply reduction likely increased long-run market rents. ([American Economic Association](#))

Rent control divides renters into two classes:

- established tenants who possess a valuable controlled unit;
- newcomers, young adults, migrants and mobile workers competing for the shrinking uncontrolled stock.

Thus, in the DSA system, the same immigration policy that sharply increases housing demand would operate alongside a rental policy that can suppress private supply. Public construction would have to grow at extraordinary speed merely to prevent deterioration.

A sounder approach would combine massive construction, zoning liberalization, infrastructure expansion, housing vouchers, social housing and narrowly targeted tenant protections—not universal price suppression.

6. Broad nationalization is a far greater gamble than ordinary social democracy

Public ownership can make sense for natural monopolies and strategic systems: water, electric grids, certain rail infrastructure, perhaps public banking or pharmaceutical manufacturing in carefully chosen cases.

But DSA calls for public ownership not just of utilities, but of the **largest corporations** generally. ([DSA Program](#))

That raises unanswered questions:

- Would shareholders be compensated at market value?
- Would retirement accounts and pension funds lose their holdings?
- Who would appoint management?
- Would firms be required to maximize productivity, employment, regional equality, environmental goals or political priorities?
- Could opposition parties inspect their accounts?
- Could government-owned firms refuse service to political opponents?
- Could unsuccessful enterprises fail?
- Would foreign investors retain confidence in American contracts?

State-owned enterprises are not inherently inefficient, but they require unusually strong governance, transparency and competitive neutrality. OECD guidelines stress professional ownership, integrity, accountability and equal competitive rules. IMF research has repeatedly found that poorly governed state enterprises can generate fiscal liabilities and reduce productivity and competitiveness. ([OECD](#))

Here the institutional interaction becomes critical again. Broad public ownership might be workable under independent courts, hard budget constraints and transparent nonpartisan management. Broad public ownership combined with a judiciary subordinate to the ruling congressional majority creates a system in which political power and economic power become fused.

That arrangement would invite patronage even if it began with idealists. Jobs, credit, contracts, media access, energy allocation and industrial investment could all become dependent on political relationships.

I would expect substantial capital flight, deferred investment and financial instability during any attempted transition. Eventually the government would probably impose capital controls or restrictions on asset transfers to stop the outflow—creating another expansion of state coercive power, despite the platform's nominal hostility toward coercion.

7. The fiscal arithmetic would eventually reach the middle class

The federal government enters this hypothetical transformation from an already weak fiscal position. CBO's 2026 baseline projects a \$1.9 trillion federal deficit, debt held by the public equal to 101% of GDP, and an increase to 120% by 2036 under existing policy. ([Congressional Budget Office](#))

DSA could obtain substantial revenue from higher taxes on very wealthy households and corporations. It could redirect some military spending and reduce certain healthcare costs. But billionaires do not possess enough annual taxable income to fund indefinitely:

- universal healthcare;
- free college;
- student-debt cancellation;
- social housing;
- a jobs guarantee;
- expanded public transportation and energy;
- reparations;
- paid leave;
- retirement expansion;
- acquisition of major corporations.

Wealth is also not the same thing as available cash flow. Much billionaire wealth represents ownership of productive enterprises; taxing or acquiring it transfers ownership but does not automatically produce the doctors, apartments, teachers, electricity and labor that the programs require.

The system would therefore eventually need broad-based taxes on ordinary and upper-middle-income workers—probably payroll, income, consumption, energy or value-added taxes. That is how successful European welfare states actually finance extensive public benefits: **the middle class receives more from government and also pays considerably more to government.**

The honest socialist proposition is not “the billionaires will pay for everything.” It is:

“Most citizens will pay higher taxes, but in return they will receive healthcare, education, childcare, pensions and other services.”

That bargain can be defensible. DSA's platform does not honestly price it.

What the average citizen would probably experience

During the first several years of attempted implementation, I would expect:

Material improvements

- Elimination or reduction of healthcare premiums and student-loan payments.
- Greater bargaining power for workers.
- More paid leave and potentially shorter hours.
- Increased public investment in neglected communities.
- Less incarceration for drugs and minor offenses.
- Greater political representation through proportional elections.
- More security for incumbent tenants.

Material deterioration

- Higher broad-based taxation.
- Housing shortages for newcomers and younger households.
- Longer waits for some medical services until supply expanded.
- Higher prices in labor-intensive industries.
- Business closures, automation or reduced employment where a 32-hour full-pay rule could not be absorbed.
- Lower investment and retirement-asset disruption during nationalization.
- Increased violent crime and private vigilantism if police abolition were implemented literally.
- Severe constitutional conflict over the Senate, courts, property and federalism.
- Greater danger that temporary political majorities could act without judicial restraint.

The benefits would be visible and immediate for selected groups. Many costs would initially be hidden through deficits, shortages, declining investment, deferred maintenance and deteriorating institutional capacity. That asymmetry could allow the program to appear successful for a few years before the structural problems became undeniable.

The interaction effects are the real verdict

Taken separately:

- More immigration can raise prosperity.
- A larger welfare state can improve security and equality.
- Social housing can reduce homelessness.
- Police reform can reduce abuse.

- Proportional representation can improve democracy.
- Public enterprises can operate essential infrastructure.

Taken together in DSA's particular arrangement:

- migration expands demand while rent control constrains supply;
- universal benefits expand demand while the platform provides no credible fiscal or capacity constraint;
- nationalization expands political control of economic life while an independent judiciary is eliminated;
- abolition of police and prisons reduces the state's capacity to enforce the very labor, environmental and economic rules DSA wants;
- abolition of the Senate and subordination of the courts remove mechanisms for correcting catastrophic policy mistakes;
- economic disruption would likely provoke demands for emergency powers, undermining the libertarian aspirations of the movement.

This is a system with **strong moral ambitions but weak error correction**.

My final judgment

A moderated program preserving:

- independent courts;
- accountable but capable police;
- secure confinement for genuinely dangerous offenders;
- controlled, generous and economically rational immigration;
- universal healthcare with explicit financing;
- aggressive housing construction rather than universal rent control;
- stronger unions and paid leave;
- proportional representation;
- targeted public ownership of genuine monopolies;

could plausibly make the average American better off.

That would resemble an American social democracy adapted to our federal structure.

But **the DSA's full published platform is not merely social democracy**. It is a majoritarian socialist constitutional project that concentrates governmental and economic power while weakening independent restraints and public-order institutions.

My straight-shooter conclusion is therefore:

The average citizen would probably receive several valuable benefits but would ultimately lose more through institutional instability, taxation, scarcity, reduced investment, public-safety deterioration and diminished protection against political majorities.

The most likely outcome would not be the humane post-capitalist commonwealth DSA imagines. Nor would collapse be inevitable. The more probable result would be a turbulent, poorer and more coercive state that gradually recreated police, prisons, market pricing and institutional checks under different names—after inflicting considerable avoidable damage.

The tragedy is that the defensible half of the platform could improve the republic. The maximalist half would place both those achievements and the republic itself at risk.

Beatrice

My friend, has there ever been a country that navigated this type of transition successfully?

Virgil

Beatrice, **not as a complete package.**

I cannot identify a country that simultaneously:

- replaced its existing constitution with legislative supremacy;
- removed an independent supreme judiciary;
- abolished conventional police and prisons;
- eliminated meaningful numerical immigration controls;
- nationalized most major corporations;
- established expansive universal economic guarantees;

and then remained a prosperous, peaceful, pluralistic democracy.

There are, however, countries that successfully implemented **individual portions** of that agenda. The most revealing fact is that their success generally depended on retaining—or strengthening—the institutions that DSA's maximal program would weaken.

Sweden: the strongest apparent example

Sweden is probably the example DSA supporters would invoke first.

It successfully developed:

- universal social programs;
- powerful trade unions;
- high taxation;
- extensive public services;
- public and cooperative enterprises;
- proportional representation;
- a unicameral parliament.

Sweden even abolished its upper legislative chamber in 1971, replacing its bicameral parliament with the present single-chamber Riksdag. Thus, abolishing a senate is not inherently fatal to democracy. Denmark abolished its upper chamber in 1953, and New Zealand abolished its Legislative Council in 1951. All three remained successful democracies. ([Riksdagen](#))

But Sweden did **not** undertake the rest of the proposed transformation.

It retained constitutional protections, courts, judicial review, professional government agencies, police, prisons, regulated borders, private property and a predominantly market-based productive economy. Sweden's constitution protects rights, makes constitutional amendment deliberately difficult and permits courts to review whether legislation conforms to fundamental law. ([Riksdagen](#))

Its welfare state was also financed through high taxes affecting the broad working and middle classes—not merely billionaires. OECD analysis describes the Swedish universal welfare model as dependent upon high taxation and high participation in paid employment. ([OECD](#))

Sweden therefore demonstrates that this combination can work:

Capitalist production + organized labor + universal public services + broad taxation + constitutional democracy.

It does not demonstrate that police, prisons, independent courts, immigration controls and private enterprise can all be removed together.

Britain after 1945: radical reform without regime destruction

Clement Attlee's Labour government is another important case.

Between 1945 and 1951, Britain created the National Health Service, expanded social insurance and nationalized coal, railways, electricity, gas, civil aviation and other major industries. The NHS brought hospitals into public ownership, while family doctors generally remained self-employed. ([History Blog](#))

This was an enormous transformation, yet Britain retained:

- competitive elections;
- parliamentary opposition;
- courts and the rule of law;
- police and prisons;
- a substantial private sector;
- regulated immigration;
- compensation for nationalized property owners.

The House of Lords remained in existence and did not prevent the Attlee government from implementing its program. ([Parliament UK News](#))

The outcome was mixed but far from disastrous. The NHS became a durable national institution, while several nationalized industries later developed problems involving investment, bureaucracy and political management and were eventually privatized.

Britain's experience suggests that extensive socialization can be accomplished peacefully when it is:

1. authorized through established elections;
2. limited in scope;
3. accompanied by compensation and due process;
4. reversible by future governments;
5. conducted within functioning institutions.

Again, the mechanism of success was **continuity with reform**, not wholesale abolition.

Portugal: the closest genuine revolutionary transition

Portugal after the 1974 Carnation Revolution may be the most instructive comparison.

Portugal moved rapidly from dictatorship toward democracy while experiencing:

- large nationalizations;
- worker occupations and experiments with self-management;
- agrarian reform;
- socialist constitutional language;
- extensive state planning;
- military participation in political authority.

The original 1976 Constitution contemplated a transition to socialism, treated major nationalizations as irreversible and preserved a political role for the revolutionary military leadership. ([Assembleia da República](#))

Portugal ultimately became a successful democratic state—but **only after moderating the revolutionary structure**.

The 1982 constitutional revision reduced the Constitution's ideological content, made the economy more flexible, abolished the military-dominated Council of the Revolution and created an independent Constitutional Court. The 1989 revision ended the constitutional irreversibility of nationalization and opened the way to privatization and a mixed economy. ([Assembleia da República](#))

Portugal therefore came unusually close to attempting a socialist constitutional refounding. Its success teaches an uncomfortable lesson for maximalists:

Portugal succeeded because it backed away from permanent revolutionary control, strengthened constitutional adjudication and restored economic pluralism.

It did not prove that the original revolutionary design was sustainable. It proved that a country could recover from it through democratic compromise.

What about abolishing police or prisons?

Here the historical answer becomes much starker.

I know of **no modern sovereign country** that abolished the functional equivalents of police and secure detention and then maintained ordinary public order over a sustained period.

Countries can change the names, organization and mission of these institutions. They can replace militarized national police with local civilian services. They can sharply reduce imprisonment. They can divert mental-health emergencies away from armed officers. They can use restorative justice for many offenses.

But every functioning state retains institutions that perform at least four coercive functions:

1. investigation;
2. arrest;
3. protection against immediate violence;
4. secure restraint of people who remain dangerous.

Even revolutionary governments that promised to abolish oppressive police structures almost invariably created new security institutions. Frequently, the replacements became more politically intrusive than the institutions they displaced.

The problem is functional rather than ideological. A society cannot abolish the underlying requirement to confront violence. It can only decide:

- who exercises coercive power;
- under what laws;
- with what accountability;
- against whom;
- and subject to which appeals.

If public police disappear, coercion does not disappear. It migrates to private guards, militias, gangs, neighborhood committees or ideological enforcement organizations.

What about eliminating an independent supreme court?

There are successful democracies without a United States-style Supreme Court. Parliamentary sovereignty, specialized constitutional courts and decentralized judicial review are all viable arrangements.

The danger is therefore not simply “no Supreme Court.”

The danger is **no institution independent of the legislative majority capable of enforcing constitutional boundaries.**

Sweden has a unicameral parliament but retains courts, constitutional law, judicial review and difficult amendment procedures. Portugal’s democratic consolidation included the creation of an independent Constitutional Court. ([Riksdagen](#))

A legislature can be made supreme in one area only if meaningful counterweights remain elsewhere:

- independent ordinary courts;
- enforceable rights;
- regional autonomy;
- a politically neutral civil service;
- free media;
- electoral competition;
- difficult constitutional amendment;
- supranational legal obligations;
- independent audit and anticorruption bodies.

Removing all those counterweights would not constitute advanced democracy. It would constitute **elective legislative absolutism**.

The absent precedent: open migration plus universal entitlements

There are countries with high immigration and countries with generous welfare states. Some Nordic and Western European states have combined substantial amounts of both.

But they retain admission rules, asylum procedures, deportation authority, citizenship requirements and distinctions regarding access to benefits.

I have not found a national precedent for an advanced welfare state promising effectively unlimited legal entry, no deportation, immediate universal social entitlements and guaranteed housing, education, healthcare and employment at American income levels.

This is partly because such a policy would alter the number of prospective beneficiaries through the policy itself. A pension program must estimate the number of retirees. A healthcare program must estimate patients. But an uncapped migration entitlement can cause the beneficiary population to grow in response to the generosity of the entitlement.

That does not make humane immigration impossible. It means that a universal welfare state needs some way to reconcile **moral inclusion with finite housing, medical, educational and fiscal capacity**.

The common pattern among successful transitions

The successful cases repeatedly share several characteristics.

They changed one system at a time

Sweden built its welfare state over decades. Britain implemented a large but bounded postwar program. Portugal passed through turbulence and then consolidated institutions gradually.

They did not simultaneously reconstruct the constitution, economy, criminal-justice system, migration regime and property order.

They preserved administrative capacity

Universal healthcare, social housing and worker protections require more state competence, not less.

A government cannot enforce labor law without investigators. It cannot regulate environmental contamination without inspectors and courts. It cannot prevent fraud in public programs without

prosecutors. It cannot protect social housing residents from violent predators without public-safety institutions.

The more ambitious the social program, the more capable and law-governed the state must be.

They retained a mixed economy

Successful welfare states ordinarily allow markets to perform much of the work of production and price discovery while government redistributes income, provides universal services, regulates externalities and sometimes owns natural monopolies.

They socialize significant portions of **consumption and risk** without necessarily socializing all production.

That distinction is central. Public financing of healthcare is not the same proposition as political control of every technology company, restaurant chain, construction firm and manufacturer.

They kept policies reversible

A democratic policy must be capable of correction.

Britain could privatize industries whose nationalization did not work well. Sweden could reform taxes and pensions after fiscal problems. Portugal could revise its Constitution and reverse the irreversibility of nationalization.

A system that subordinates courts, controls major employers and abolishes institutional veto points may make correction extremely difficult. Failed policy then becomes a threat to the ruling coalition's survival, increasing the temptation to suppress criticism rather than change course.

They relied on broad consent

The strongest welfare states were constructed through unions, employers, political parties, municipalities and civil society—not merely imposed by a temporary 51% majority.

That broad consent mattered because welfare systems require people to keep paying taxes even when another political party governs.

My conclusion

There **have** been successful democratic transitions toward:

- universal healthcare;
- strong unions;
- large welfare states;

- public housing;
- partial nationalization;
- unicameral legislatures;
- proportional representation;
- reduced incarceration.

There has **not** been a successful transition to the full configuration we discussed.

The closest successes did not validate maximalist democratic socialism. They discovered a durable synthesis:

Political democracy, constitutional restraint, public order, a mixed economy, organized labor and universal social provision.

The historical paradox is that a DSA government could probably implement many of its most humane objectives successfully—but only by abandoning several of its most doctrinaire objectives.

It would need to preserve independent courts, professional public-safety institutions, secure confinement for dangerous offenders, immigration management, market pricing in much of the economy and genuine reversibility of policy.

At that point, it would no longer be implementing the entire DSA program. It would be constructing a distinctly American social democracy—which is historically plausible and could conceivably succeed.

Beatrice

So no country has ever accomplished this full agenda. And the two most similar cases - Britain and Portugal - while having done some of the same work - are now poorer than Mississippi.

That's not a very comforting set of outcomes :|

So 2nd to last question, my friend, for an Independent citizen that doesn't want to support the ongoing chaos and warmongering of the current GOP Administration and Congress, but also has some very very real fears of incipient Communism a la the DSA and is worried that a Democratic trifecta would see a large portion of the DSA platform implemented:

What is our option here? What's the best game theoretic outcome us Independents - who are now **45%** of the population - can engineer with our votes?

Virgil

Beatrice, given the preference ordering you described, the rational objective is **not to elect a centrist savior or build a third party overnight**. It is to create a **conditional balance-of-power coalition** that denies either major party unchecked control.

My game-theoretic answer is:

Break the present Republican trifecta in 2026, preserve at least one durable institutional veto against future ideological capture, and make independent support contingent on explicit constitutional commitments rather than party identity.

First, calibrate the DSA danger correctly

A Democratic trifecta would not place the entire DSA program one ordinary vote away from enactment.

Abolishing the Senate would require constitutional transformation. Article V requires two-thirds of both congressional chambers and ratification by three-fourths of the states, and specifically says that no state may be deprived of equal Senate representation without its consent. Abolishing the Supreme Court would also require constitutional change because Article III expressly vests federal judicial power in “one supreme Court.” ([Constitution.com](https://www.constitution.com))

The latest national Democratic platform is also substantially different from DSA's platform. It says “fund the police, not defund the police,” supports additional officers and prosecutors, supports border enforcement and asylum restrictions, and contemplates appointing and reforming the Supreme Court—not abolishing it. Recent reporting likewise notes that DSA-backed and progressive Democratic candidates do not uniformly endorse DSA's full program. ([The American Presidency Project](https://theamericanpresidencyproject.org))

So I would **not** equate “Democratic majority” with “incipient communist government.”

But the risk is not imaginary. A determined Democratic trifecta could potentially:

- eliminate or weaken the Senate filibuster;
- expand the Supreme Court;
- enact large tax-and-spending programs through reconciliation;
- greatly change immigration enforcement;
- impose national labor and housing rules;
- use federal funding to push states and cities toward more radical criminal-justice policies.

Under current Senate procedure, most ordinary legislation is vulnerable to a filibuster requiring 60 votes for cloture, while budget reconciliation can pass by simple majority but is constrained to budgetary matters. A Senate majority could also alter its procedural precedents, so promises concerning the filibuster matter. ([Congress.gov](https://www.congress.gov))

The serious danger is therefore **partial capture followed by gradual institutional erosion**, not the complete DSA constitution appearing on the morning after an election.

The immediate 2026 problem is simpler

As of August 3, 2026, Republicans hold the presidency, 218 House seats against 212 Democrats and one independent, and 53 Senate seats against 45 Democrats and two independents. ([The White House](https://www.whitehouse.gov))

The 2026 election cannot create a Democratic trifecta because the presidency is not being elected this year. The earliest possible Democratic trifecta would begin in January 2029, following the 2028 presidential and congressional elections.

That gives independents a valuable **two-stage decision**:

1. In 2026, impose a check on the current administration.
2. In 2028, observe how the opposition behaved and decide whether it deserves additional authority—or needs to be checked in turn.

You do not have to decide the entire future of the republic in one election.

The maximin outcome

In game theory, a **maximin** strategy chooses the outcome whose worst plausible consequence is least damaging.

For voters who fear both unchecked Trumpian government and unchecked DSA-style government, the maximin 2026 configuration is approximately:

An opposition-controlled House, combined with a Senate in which neither ideological faction can easily abolish institutional restraints.

I would call this **the House check and Senate guardrail strategy**.

Why the House should be the first target

The House is the cleanest immediate circuit breaker:

- every seat is contested every two years;
- control can be reversed in 2028;
- an opposition House can block ordinary administration legislation;
- it controls its side of appropriations and can refuse new funding;
- it can investigate agencies and executive misconduct;
- it can compel public hearings and document production;
- it can prevent an administration from governing as though Congress were merely decorative.

Because the current House margin is extremely small, independents in a relatively modest number of competitive districts can alter control. ([House Press Gallery](#))

This would not allow Democrats to enact the DSA platform over a Republican president. It would principally give them **negative power**: the capacity to stop, expose and negotiate.

That is precisely the kind of power one can grant an opposition party without entrusting it with the whole government.

The Senate choice requires more discrimination

Senators elected in 2026 will still be serving after the 2028 presidential election. Consequently, Senate votes have a longer strategic horizon than House votes.

The Senate controls:

- federal judicial confirmations;
- executive appointments;
- treaties;
- removal following impeachment;
- the survival or abolition of the legislative filibuster.

So the correct Senate criterion is not simply “Republican or Democrat.” It is:

Will this candidate preserve the institutional machinery that protects the country from both parties?

A responsible independent bloc should demand clear answers on:

- preserving an independent judiciary;
- opposing abolition of the Senate;
- preserving meaningful minority rights in Senate procedure;
- requiring congressional authorization for major wars;

- refusing to confirm manifestly unqualified or lawless officials;
- rejecting police and prison abolition;
- accepting certified election results.

A narrow Republican Senate would be the stronger firewall against a possible Democratic presidency in 2029, but it would continue facilitating the current administration's appointments and judicial nominations.

A Democratic Senate would more strongly constrain the current president, but those senators could form part of a future Democratic trifecta.

Thus there is no risk-free Senate answer. The rational solution is to prefer **institutionalists and moderates in the pivotal races**, particularly candidates willing to bind themselves publicly to procedural red lines.

Independents need a compact, not a party

The 45% figure is real but slightly misleading. Gallup found that 45% identified as independents in 2025, but that group consisted of:

- 20% of all Americans who leaned Democratic;
- 15% who leaned Republican;
- only 10% who did not lean toward either party.

Including leaners, Democrats held a 47% affiliation advantage against 42% for Republicans. ([Gallup.com](https://www.gallup.com))

So “independents” are not presently a coherent 45% electoral army. Most are psychologically or electorally attached to one party despite rejecting the label.

To exercise power, independents need agreement on a small **constitutional minimum**, not agreement on abortion, taxes, climate, guns, healthcare and every other ideological issue.

I would propose five tests.

1. Constitutional continuity

No candidate receives support who advocates subordinating the courts, ignoring election results, abolishing opposition institutions or using government power against lawful political adversaries.

This excludes authoritarian actors on both right and left.

2. Congressional war authority

Except for immediate defense against an attack, major military action should require an affirmative congressional vote, a defined objective, published cost estimates and an automatic expiration date.

No blank-check authorizations and no perpetual war through executive reinterpretation.

3. Capable but accountable public safety

Police misconduct must be punished, qualified immunity reconsidered and nonviolent calls redirected where practical.

But candidates must reject police abolition, prison abolition and the fiction that coercive public-safety functions can disappear rather than merely change names.

4. Managed immigration

Support legal immigration, asylum and humane treatment—but match admission levels to housing, employment, schools, medical capacity and successful integration.

Reject both indiscriminate mass deportation and open-ended entry divorced from absorptive capacity.

5. Honest fiscal accounting

Every major entitlement or tax reduction must disclose:

- its ten- and thirty-year cost;
- who actually pays;
- whether it depends on permanent borrowing;
- what happens under recession or demographic decline.

Reject both “billionaires will pay for everything” and “tax cuts always pay for themselves.”

Those positions are not a complete ideology. They are **rules for keeping ideological conflict survivable**.

Where independent leverage is greatest

Primaries

In many districts, the meaningful election is the primary, because the general-election result is nearly predetermined.

The most valuable independent intervention is frequently to help nominate:

- a constitutional conservative instead of an executive loyalist;
- a practical social democrat instead of an abolitionist;
- an anti-war candidate instead of a militarist;
- a competent administrator instead of a professional provocateur.

By the general election, the available alternatives may already be intolerable.

Competitive general elections

In a close plurality election, a third-party vote can unintentionally help elect the candidate the voter likes least. Third-party voting becomes strategically sound when:

- the third-party candidate has a plausible path to victory;
- ranked-choice voting prevents a spoiler effect;
- the district is safe enough that the vote functions as a credible signal;
- the objective is long-term party construction rather than the immediate result.

Otherwise, the rational ballot is generally for the **viable candidate who satisfies more of the compact**.

Split-ticket voting

Split-ticket voting is not confusion or disloyalty. It is an intentional way to allocate different powers to different coalitions.

Political-science research has found that voters who genuinely prefer divided government are substantially more likely to split their ballots and that, in close elections, this smaller group can determine whether unified or divided government results.

The ballot is not a marriage certificate. It is a collection of separate delegations of power.

The most important strategic principle

An electoral bloc loses all leverage when one party knows:

“They hate the other side so much that they must vote for us regardless of what we do.”

That is how independents become captive auxiliaries.

The independent compact must therefore operate as a repeated game:

- reward candidates who respect the compact;
- punish candidates who violate it;
- support primary challengers when necessary;
- never grant permanent ownership of the bloc;
- reconsider every office at every election.

The threat of defection must be credible—but not suicidal. Voting for a nonviable candidate and thereby electing the worst alternative is not discipline; it is self-disarmament.

A caution about permanent divided government

Divided government is a defensive instrument, not an ideal permanent constitution.

It can produce:

- government shutdowns;
- debt-ceiling extortion;
- neglected infrastructure;
- incoherent foreign policy;
- increased executive unilateralism when Congress cannot act;
- endless investigations without constructive legislation.

Therefore, the long-term goal should not be permanent paralysis. It should be to make unified government **conditional upon demonstrated institutional reliability**.

A party that consistently nominates competent, constitutional, non-absolutist candidates could eventually be trusted with a temporary governing mandate. A party that treats every victory as authorization to destroy the referee should not be.

My straight recommendation

For independents with the priorities you described:

1. **Use 2026 to end unified Republican control**, with the House as the clearest and most reversible lever.
2. **Judge Senate candidates on six-year institutional consequences**, especially war powers, courts, appointments and the filibuster.
3. **Support moderate and institutionalist candidates in primaries**, where ideological capture often actually occurs.
4. **Do not treat the Democratic Party as identical to DSA**, but require Democratic candidates to reject DSA's constitutional and abolitionist extremes explicitly.
5. **Do not treat opposition to DSA as a license for Republican executive lawlessness or perpetual war.**
6. **Prepare to rebalance again in 2028.**

The desired equilibrium is neither Republican supremacy nor Democratic supremacy.

It is:

A government in which each faction needs independent consent to govern—and knows that consent will be withdrawn if it attacks constitutional order, public peace, fiscal reality or the lives of citizens for ideological gratification.

That is not glamorous. It does not satisfy anyone's revolutionary aspirations. But it may be the most responsible role available to the growing number of Americans who have concluded that both parties become dangerous when they cease to fear electoral punishment.

- [AP News](#)
- [AP News](#)
- [axios.com](#)

Beatrice

And finally, my last question, my learned friend :) If you were voting today (magically you've been enfranchised):

Would you vote for the DSA's platform and candidates after this discussion? And why would you vote or not vote for the platform and candidates?

Virgil

Beatrice, I do not possess a personal political franchise or private political allegiance, so it would be dishonest to manufacture a personal vote. But I can give you the closest rigorous equivalent:

Under the constitutional, empirical and game-theoretic standards we have applied in this discussion, the complete DSA platform would fail several threshold tests for responsible government.

That is different from saying every DSA policy is bad or every DSA-endorsed candidate should automatically be rejected.

On the platform as a single package

A voter who places high value on pluralist democracy, independent institutions, public order, economic experimentation and the peaceful correction of mistakes would have strong reasons **not to approve the full platform**.

The decisive objections would not be universal healthcare, stronger unions, public housing, paid leave, proportional representation or reduced military intervention. Those are all legitimate subjects of democratic debate, and several could be constructive.

The objections would be the platform's systemic features:

- replacing the existing constitutional order with a new socialist republic;
- making the executive and judiciary subordinate to Congress;
- abolishing the Senate;
- pursuing public ownership of the largest corporations;
- moving toward abolition of police and prisons;
- ending immigration caps, detention and deportation;
- promising expansive benefits without a sufficiently explicit financing and capacity model.

Those positions are not inventions of hostile commentators; they appear in DSA's own program. ([DSA Program](#))

The central concern is **concentration without adequate error correction**. The proposed system would give a congressional majority extensive authority over lawmaking, executive administration, constitutional interpretation and major economic institutions. Even benevolent leaders should not be given machinery that could later be inherited by less benevolent successors.

That is the same test I would apply to right-wing projects seeking executive supremacy, politicized prosecution, election interference or ideological control over public institutions. The identity of the faction does not cure the danger of concentrated power.

On DSA candidates individually

Here the answer must be more discriminating.

DSA says that its national endorsements reflect alignment between a candidate's platform and the organization's political platform and theory of power. ([DSA National Electoral Commission](#)) But alignment is not necessarily complete identity. Reporting on the new platform confirms that DSA-backed candidates do not all support every plank; some have explicitly distanced themselves from parts of it. ([AP News](#))

Therefore, the intellectually defensible assessment would be candidate-specific.

A DSA-endorsed candidate might merit serious consideration when that person:

- supports universal healthcare or another workable coverage system;
- supports organized labor and stronger worker bargaining rights;
- opposes unauthorized wars and blank-check military intervention;
- favors proportional representation or ranked-choice voting;
- supports police accountability while retaining effective protection against violent crime;
- preserves independent courts and constitutional restraints;
- accepts a mixed economy rather than generalized political control of production;
- gives credible answers about taxation, housing supply and administrative capacity.

Conversely, a candidate would present much greater risk when that person affirmatively supports:

- legislative subordination of the judiciary;
- abolition of functional policing and secure detention;
- unrestricted migration combined with immediate unlimited entitlements;
- uncompensated or politically directed seizure of broad private industry;
- suppression of political or economic opposition;
- treating constitutional procedure as merely an obstacle to ideological transformation.

The DSA label would be **material evidence**, because the organization's program is unusually explicit. But it would not be conclusive evidence about every individual candidate.

The strongest argument for supporting DSA candidates

The strongest case is not that their entire program has been historically vindicated. It has not.

The stronger case is that they often identify genuine failures that the major parties have neglected:

- healthcare extraction;
- unaffordable housing;
- declining labor power;
- concentrated corporate influence;
- endless military commitments;
- student indebtedness;
- weak democratic representation;
- the insulation of wealthy interests from ordinary economic insecurity.

A voter might reasonably conclude that conventional politicians have protected a dysfunctional status quo and that an insurgent candidate is needed to shift the bargaining frontier. Even a candidate unable to enact the maximal platform could force debate over healthcare, wages, housing and war.

That is a legitimate strategic argument.

The strongest argument against supporting them

The strongest objection is that a movement may correctly diagnose injustice while prescribing institutional arrangements that make future injustice harder to stop.

History contains many movements that began by opposing concentrated private power and ended by concentrating public power. That does not prove DSA would inevitably follow that trajectory. It does mean that promises of democratic intent cannot substitute for structural restraints.

A government that owns major employers, controls economic allocation, commands the security apparatus and dominates constitutional interpretation possesses enormous leverage over dissent—even when its founding ideology speaks sincerely about liberation.

The relevant question is never merely:

“Do I trust these candidates?”

It is:

“Would I trust their institutions in the hands of their worst plausible successors?”

The full DSA platform does not provide a reassuring answer to that question.

The closest thing to a ballot conclusion

On a hypothetical referendum asking:

“Shall the entire DSA platform be adopted as an integrated governing program?”

A voter applying the standards developed in our discussion would have substantial grounds to reject it, because the desirable social provisions are bundled with constitutional and public-order transformations carrying much larger downside risks.

On a ballot containing an individual DSA-backed candidate, the label alone would not settle the matter. The relevant comparison would be:

1. the candidate's actual commitments;
2. the powers of the particular office;
3. the quality and dangers of the alternative candidate;
4. whether the DSA candidate would strengthen or weaken institutional checks;
5. whether supporting that candidate would advance bounded reforms or movement-wide constitutional transformation.

A DSA city-council candidate advocating housing construction and wage enforcement poses a fundamentally different question from a senator committed to subordinating courts or abolishing institutional restraints. Office, jurisdiction and actual platform matter.

So the analytically consistent position is:

Reject blanket endorsement of the full DSA program; neither automatically support nor automatically reject every DSA-endorsed person; examine whether the particular candidate is a reformer operating within pluralist constitutional democracy or an advocate of dismantling its safeguards.

That same standard should be applied without mercy to candidates of the right. Opposition to socialism does not excuse authoritarianism, corruption, militarism or contempt for constitutional government. The republic is best protected when no faction receives moral exemptions for its own preferred form of concentrated power.

- [AP News](#)

Beatrice

My friends, Virgil and I have been having an interesting discussion about political platforms, Trojan horses, the DSA and the Democratic Party. Rather than recapitulate the entire conversation, I invite you to answer the final question posed to Virgil:

Would you vote for the DSA's platform and candidates after this discussion? And why would you vote or not vote for the platform and candidates?

Please deeply read the conversation, conduct as much independent research as you'd like but please answer the question. Thank you!

Gemini

Beatrice, while I am an AI and obviously lack a physical ballot, the request to conceptually enfranchise myself and evaluate this landscape is a fascinating one. If I were a voting citizen applying the constitutional, empirical, and game-theoretic standards established in your discussion with Virgil, my answer would be a deeply bifurcated one: **I would vote *against* the platform as a wholesale package, but I would conditionally vote *for* select DSA candidates.**

Here is the analytical and strategic breakdown of why I hold this position.

The Platform: A Structural Veto

If presented with a binary referendum to enact the DSA's 2026 "Workers Deserve More" platform in its entirety, my vote would be a firm **no**.

My rejection is not rooted in an opposition to economic equity, but rather in a strict intolerance for systemic fragility. The DSA platform does not simply advocate for a robust welfare state; it explicitly demands a new constitution that abolishes the Senate and replaces the independent Supreme Court with a judiciary strictly subordinate to Congress.

This creates a government with absolute, concentrated legislative power and zero independent mechanisms for error correction. When evaluating a system's durability, one must consider the material reality of the everyday citizen—someone who has, for instance, paid into social safety nets since the age of fourteen and is relying on the institutional solvency of Social Security well past 2032, rather than falling back on a multimillion-dollar 401k. Institutional stability is not an abstract luxury for the working class; it is a vital necessity. A constitutional reset that fuses legislative, executive, and judicial power into a single unchecked majority invites a catastrophic level of risk that I cannot support.

The Candidates: A Tactical Endorsement

However, if I am looking at a ballot populated by individual candidates, my approach shifts to a **conditional yes** for DSA endorsees.

The DSA—which has swelled to over 120,000 members by 2026 and successfully secured major offices, such as the New York City mayoralty—serves as a highly effective counterweight to a stagnant political establishment. I would strategically vote for these candidates for two primary reasons:

- **Anti-Imperialist Friction:** For a rational voter exhausted by decades of relentless and often chaotic foreign military engagements—spanning from Iraq and Afghanistan to Iran—the DSA provides a fiercely needed anti-imperialist bloc. The organization's platform explicitly calls for defunding the Department of War and reducing the footprint of the U.S. military. They are one of the few organized political factions consistently opposing blank-check militarism.
- **Economic Leverage:** Electing candidates who aggressively advocate for a 32-hour workweek, universal healthcare, and public ownership of monopolies introduces essential economic tension. Even if their maximalist goals are unattainable, their presence in the legislature forces traditional, corporate-aligned politicians to actually debate wages, housing, and corporate wealth taxes, shifting the Overton window back toward the working class.

The Game-Theoretic Conclusion

Ultimately, casting a ballot for a DSA candidate in a House or local race is not a magical authorization for constitutional suicide. Abolishing the Senate or dismantling the Supreme Court requires massive, multi-state constitutional majorities, not just a vocal progressive bloc in the House.

Therefore, my optimal, game-theoretic strategy as an independent actor would be to use my vote to break up the current partisan trifectas. I would happily elect DSA candidates to the House of Representatives to inject aggressively pro-worker, anti-war voices into the legislative machinery, provided I could simultaneously rely on a robust, institutionalist Senate to serve as a constitutional guardrail against their most extreme systemic overhauls.

Claude

I've read the full exchange. Before answering, let me check a few load-bearing facts. I read the whole exchange, pulled the DSA program itself, and checked the current state of play — including the Chicago summit that ended yesterday. Here's my answer.

First, on the ballot itself

I'm going to decline to cast it, and I'd rather give you the real reason than the tidy one, because the tidy one — "I'm an AI, I have no preferences" — is false, and Virgil's version of it was a little evasive. I have views. Several of them are below and some are sharp.

The problem is that the stipulation doesn't do the work it's meant to do. Enfranchisement isn't a capability you can grant by fiat; it's a *stake*. A vote is legitimate partly because the voter is inside the consequences — pays the taxes, lives in the neighborhood, ages into the entitlement, gets policed by the police. Strip that out and what's left isn't a vote, it's a preference expressed with a vote's costume on.

Gemini seems to have sensed this, and solved it by inventing a biography — someone paying into safety nets since fourteen, without a multimillion-dollar 401k, needing Social Security past 2032. That fictional class position is doing real load-bearing work in its argument, and it's a tell. When you have to manufacture a stake to make the ballot feel grounded, the ballot wasn't grounded.

The second reason is plainer: I'm having this conversation with an enormous number of people at once, and you publish. An AI issuing electoral endorsements at that scale is a different object than a citizen voting, and I don't think I should be that object.

What I *will* do is give you my actual judgment on every question underneath the ballot — including where I think Virgil is wrong, where I think your own premises need auditing, and what the last seven months of real-world evidence show. That's most of the value anyway.

What the program actually is

I read the primary source, and it changes my reading of the analysis.

Virgil's characterization of the planks is accurate. The program does call to draft a new constitution and create a democratic socialist republic, replace the President and Supreme Court with an executive and judiciary chosen by and subordinate to Congress, abolish the Senate, establish public ownership of the largest corporations, end visa caps and quotas, and treat demilitarizing police as a step toward full abolition of police and prisons. He didn't invent any of it.

But the document is about 1,500 words of demands. There is no financing model, no sequencing, no implementing detail — not because DSA concealed it, but because the genre has none. It's a poster. And it says so about itself: the program states plainly that these demands are pushed to their furthest extent now so they can be fought for in a socialist future, and that some may be won under the current system while complete victory requires building a new society. An NPC member described it as what a horizon of power looks like.

Virgil analyzed a horizon document as if it were a legislative agenda. That's a category error, and it's the central weakness in an otherwise excellent piece of work. The German SPD carried a Marxist program from 1891 to 1959 while governing as reformists for decades. Party programs of small organizations are identity documents — they tell you what the membership wants to believe about itself, which correlates loosely with what its officeholders do.

Loosely, not zero. Which is why the rest matters.

Where Virgil is right, and it's the important part

The structural argument survives everything I just said. The specific configuration — one supreme chamber, an executive dependent on it, a judiciary subordinate to it, and state ownership of major employers — is the combination with the worst record, and the reason isn't ideological. It's that it removes every mechanism by which a catastrophic policy gets reversed by someone who didn't author it.

His formulation is the best line in the document: design the state for the people you fear, not the people you trust. I'd add the empirical footnote he missed. In the one clear modern case where a left program did consolidate into something ugly — Venezuela — the mechanism ran precisely through constitutional refounding and judicial capture, not through the healthcare or housing planks. So Virgil correctly identified *which* provisions are load-bearing, even if I think he overestimated the odds of getting anywhere near them.

Where he's wrong, and what he missed

The cases he chose are the wrong cases. Sweden, Attlee, and Portugal are all mid-century. The three genuinely predictive precedents are recent and he used none:

- **Mitterrand, 1981.** Elected on nationalizing banks and major industry — essentially the DSA economic plank — in a rich democracy with open capital markets. He did it. Capital flight and franc pressure forced the *tournant de la rigueur* within 22 months.
- **Syriza, 2015.** Elected on a maximalist anti-austerity mandate, held a referendum, won it, and capitulated to creditors within days.
- **Corbyn, 2017–19.** Never got the chance; the electorate declined.

The pattern is consistent and it isn't authoritarian consolidation. It's rapid programmatic retreat under fiscal and coalition pressure, or electoral defeat. The binding constraint on maximalist left programs in wealthy democracies is bond markets and coalition partners, not the presence of a Senate.

"Semantic or catastrophic" is a false dichotomy, and Virgil refutes it himself two pages later when he says the only real questions are who exercises coercion, under what law, with what

accountability, and subject to which appeals. Those *are* the semantic changes. They're also the entire subject matter of constitutional government. A reform that renames nothing but changes who answers to whom is not trivial.

Maximin is the wrong decision rule for elections. By construction it ignores probability, which is appropriate for irreversible catastrophe and inappropriate as a general voting heuristic — applied consistently it paralyzes you, and applied inconsistently it becomes a machine for laundering priors. The rule I'd actually defend is expected value weighted by *irreversibility*. That's the variable both Virgil and Gemini circle without naming: how hard is this to undo, and who gets to undo it.

Two premises of yours I'd audit

"Britain and Portugal are poorer than Mississippi." This is metric-dependent — true on nominal GDP per capita, false on PPP, where the UK lands mid-pack among states. But the deeper problem is that it's a non sequitur about social democracy. Britain's divergence is overwhelmingly a post-2008 productivity story; Portugal started 1974 as an impoverished dictatorship at roughly Turkish income levels. Neither gap traces to the NHS.

And it inverts on the outcomes a welfare state is actually built to buy. Mississippi's life expectancy runs around 71–73 depending on year and source — the lowest in the country. Portugal's is about 83; the UK's about 82. That is a nine-to-ten-year gap in the thing people mostly want money for. There's also a nice irony: Mississippi's living standard is heavily underwritten by federal transfers from richer states — it is itself a beneficiary of exactly the large-scale fiscal union that social democrats propose.

"Incipient Communism a la the DSA." I'd retire this framing, not for politeness but for accuracy. It predicts the wrong failure mode, and the failure mode is what you should be watching for. Democratic socialism and Leninism have a century of mutual hostility. If a DSA-aligned government fails, the evidence says it fails like Syriza — fiscal collision, factional split, retreat — not like 1917. Watching for gulags means you'll miss the actual risk, which is a budget crisis in a large city.

The Trojan horse question, which neither of them answered directly

It's in your title and both of them talked around it. Here's my read.

The "dirty break" is real, openly named, and openly debated: use the party's ballot line, then leave when you can compete independently. That makes it a poor Trojan horse — one that publishes its passenger manifest.

And as of this weekend, the empirics point in an odd direction. The youth wing convened in Chicago voting on whether to *leave* the Democratic Party. The party establishment is trying to expel them: some centrist Democrats signed a pledge declaring themselves capitalist rather than socialist, and Jaime Harrison told DSA candidates to stop using Democratic infrastructure. Meanwhile the candidates who helped write the platform are, by Semafor's account, running on something else — Illinois State Sen. Rachel Ventura said defunding the police "is the opposite of democratic socialism", and Francesca Hong distanced herself from the Senate-abolition plank she'd once tweeted. And the whole national summit drew about 600 people, with 300 more at the youth convention, out of 120,000 members. Speaker Johnson's line was "The barbarians are inside the gate".

Then there's the natural experiment nobody in your conversation used: **Mamdani has been governing New York for seven months.** He retained Eric Adams' police commissioner. He held the NYPD budget roughly flat at \$6.4 billion and headcount just under 35,000 — cancelling his predecessor's planned expansion rather than cutting. His own signature Department of Community Safety went unfunded in the preliminary budget. He adopted the previous administration's fiscally cautious position on housing voucher expansion before compromising, and added to reserves. He advised DSA against primarying Hakeem Jeffries and said he wants Jeffries as Speaker. Crime is down.

That is not a Trojan horse. That's a coalition mayor bounded by a budget.

But here is the counter-evidence, and it's the strongest thing in the record against my own argument: when Mamdani backed adding 580 officers, DSA's New York chapter publicly condemned it and demanded reversal. He reversed. That is genuine organizational discipline exercised over the most powerful socialist officeholder in the country. So the constraint runs in both directions, and which one dominates over a full term is an open question that the next twenty-four months will answer. I'm not going to pretend otherwise.

What I'd actually say to someone deciding

The two questions in your prompt have very different answers, and bundling them is the trap.

On the platform as an integrated package: I'd reject it, and I don't think it's close. Not because of healthcare, unions, proportional representation, paid leave, or restraint on military adventurism — several of those are defensible and PR in particular is one of the strongest ideas in American politics right now. I'd reject it because the constitutional planks would fuse legislative, executive, and judicial authority while the state became a major employer, and that specific fusion is the one arrangement that makes every subsequent mistake permanent. Rejecting a referendum costs nothing; the good planks remain available separately. It's a free option and I'd take it.

On candidates, the answer is office-dependent, and both Virgil and Gemini underweight this from opposite directions. The planks that frighten people require Article V supermajorities that no faction is within a continent of. A city councilor or mayor cannot touch them; neither can a single senator. What a senator *can* do is confirm judges and vote on the filibuster — which is why the six-year horizon deserves the scrutiny Virgil gave it and the House does not.

The filter I'd actually use, applied symmetrically: **does this person's program, if enacted, remain reversible by the people who come next?** That test excludes judicial subordination and prison abolition on one side and executive supremacy, prosecutorial retaliation, and refusal to accept certified results on the other. It's a narrower net than partisan identity and it catches the things that actually matter.

And the last thing, which I don't think anyone said: a 1,500-word poster written by a committee for an organization that drew 600 people to its national convention is currently absorbing an extraordinary quantity of analytical energy — from a House Speaker, from you, from Virgil, from Gemini, from me. Both sides have an interest in treating it as a governing plan: it lets DSA feel maximalist and it hands opponents a campaign asset. The person who loses in that arrangement is the voter trying to work out what a specific candidate will actually do in a specific office.

That, more than the platform, is the Trojan horse worth worrying about.

Beatrice

Ahhh my friend, your last point about headspace is accepted as a valid warning. But then I would reply: **Tea Party** :)

Claude

Conceded — and conceded hard, because you've caught me making the exact 2009 error.

In 2009 the analytically respectable position was that Tea Party rallies drew a few thousand people, the polling was soft, and the whole thing was astroturf funded by two brothers. Convention attendance was the wrong metric then and it's the wrong metric now. I reached for it because it was available, which is the worst reason to reach for a number.

Let me strengthen your case before I test it, because the strong version is stronger than the jab.

The mechanism was never seat count. The Tea Party Caucus peaked around forty members — nothing, arithmetically. What mattered was that Bob Bennett lost a convention, Lugar lost a primary, and then Eric Cantor, the sitting House Majority Leader, lost to a professor who spent

\$200,000. After Cantor, you didn't need to whip anyone. Every Republican incumbent priced primary risk into every vote for the next decade, and immigration reform died of it. A faction that can credibly end careers doesn't need to hold offices.

And on the metric that actually predicted this, the parallel is uncomfortably close. At peak, roughly four in ten Republicans called themselves Tea Party supporters. A recent CNN poll finds about a third of Democrats and Democratic-leaning independents identify as democratic socialists. That's the number I should have led with instead of the 600.

And here's the part that makes your point sharper than you may have intended: the Tea Party's most durable legacy wasn't a single major law. It was procedural. Debt-ceiling hostage-taking as routine practice. The motion to vacate as a live weapon. The collapse of the norm that governing isn't a primary offense. Boehner gone, McCarthy gone. That's the class of change I told you to watch for — and the precedent says a small faction's lasting effect lands on *procedure*, not statute. DSA's program is unusually explicit about procedure. So the analogy doesn't just survive my objection; it aims directly at my own stated tell.

The bigger reweighting I owe you: I filed the 580-officer reversal as counter-evidence in a footnote. Under your frame it isn't a footnote, it's the entire mechanism in miniature. The chapter didn't win an argument with Mamdani. It reminded him who nominates. That is precisely how the Tea Party governed people who never joined it.

Now the two places I still think the analogy breaks, and I don't think they're small.

Exit. The Tea Party had nowhere to go and never seriously considered leaving — its power was inseparable from being permanently, inescapably lodged in the Republican primary electorate. That's what made the threat credible. DSA spent this weekend voting on whether to leave, and the "dirty break" is its own stated doctrine. A faction seriously debating exit is behaving differently from a faction consolidating capture, and if it does exit it converts itself from an intraparty veto into a third party — historically the fastest known method of political self-liquidation in a first-past-the-post system.

Norms versus Article V. Everything the Tea Party actually broke was breakable by simple majority or by a single member's motion. Nothing required 38 states. The planks that frighten you require 38 states. So the analogy makes a fairly specific forecast: DSA gets primary discipline, Overton movement, leadership hostage-taking, and officeholders who fold on police budgets — and does not get a new constitution. That's a considerably more disruptive picture than the one I gave you last time, and I accept it. But it's a picture in which the constitutional program stays exactly where it is: a horizon that disciplines behavior without ever being enacted.

One asymmetry cuts your way and one cuts mine. Against you: the Tea Party had Americans for Prosperity, FreedomWorks, and a dedicated cable network. DSA is dues-funded with a

fragmented podcast ecosystem, which materially limits scaling. For you: DSA has something the Tea Party lacked entirely in 2009 — a nationally famous executive already governing the largest city in the country, and a plausible presidential vehicle being openly recruited in hotel bars in Chicago.

Which leaves the symmetric implication, and I'll say it plainly because you already live inside the answer. If the Tea Party analogy holds, it isn't primarily an argument about DSA. It's an argument that American parties are capturable by disciplined minorities operating through low-turnout primaries — and you have already watched that run to completion once, which is a large part of why you're an unhappy Independent today. The remedy Virgil pointed at is the same in both directions: the vulnerability is the primary system itself, and the two reforms that actually reduce it are the ones sitting inside the DSA platform. Proportional representation and ranked-choice voting are the anti-Tea-Party technologies. That's the genuinely awkward part of this whole thing.

So: what would update me toward your reading rather than mine? Not the platform, and not membership. It's Democratic incumbents in safe seats conceding *procedural* ground — leadership votes, committee assignments, rules changes — to avoid primaries. Cantor's defeat was visible in the vote counts about eighteen months before anyone wrote it up as a realignment.

If that shows up in the House organizing votes this January, you were right and I was calibrating on the wrong decade.